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## From the editor-in-chief

An "international migraine" is how former US secretary of state Madeleine Albright described Pakistan after the Mumbai mayhem. It may be that for the rest of the world but for India it is a malignant tumour in its brain. It has been so for the last 60 years. After 26/11, it crossed a new threshold of pain which needs immediate intervention. The Mumbai attack is different from all the recent terror attacks since the one on Parliament in 2001 because it was a planned military-type invasion even if it only involved 10 attackers.

There were early signs that all was not well with Pakistan's fledgling democracy. First, President Zardari made all the right noises. He said: "I am hurt, I am bleeding... I feel the pain. I feel their loss and my heart goes out to their loss and the people you have lost." Then his prime minister, Yousuf Raza Gilani, offered to send the ISI director-general to cooperate with the investigation. Within 24 hours, Zardari wriggled his way out with an interesting turn of phrase: "It was a miscommunication" between the two prime ministers. Suddenly, the mood changed. It was 'show us the evidence and then we will take action'. It was clear that the civil administration was not in charge any more. There was a new undeclared boss and that was Pakistan's army chief, General Ashfaq Kiyani.

This is the reason he is the subject of this week's cover story. General Kiyani last year allied with the democratic forces to oust President Musharraf. At that time he looked like the quiet general who would get the army out of politics and stick to the business of defending Pakistan. Then came the attacks on Mumbai with fingerprints of Pakistan's ISI all over it. After all the somersaulting of the Pakistan Government, it became clear that the man who really called the shots had a much larger and deeper game plan in mind.

General Kiyani is a worried man with the increasing pressure from America to escalate the war on their Afghan border and the likelihood of Barack Obama's presidency shifting focus from Iraq to Afghanistan. Besides, the army is fighting a highly unpopular war of killing fellow Muslims at the behest of a much reviled foreign power. What better to get America off its back and get popular with the general public than launch a thinly disguised covert attack on India. Nothing unites Pakistan more than the prospect of fighting India. A predictably bellicose India gives the general the excuse to shift his troops to the Indian border and slow down the war on the Afghan front.

Pakistan has resorted to its usual denials and cosmetic action. But it is playing a dangerous game. It is torn between intra-religious warfare between Shias and Sunnis, two of Pakistan's four provinces are wrecked by insurgencies and the economy is in a shambles. Taking a hostile posture to contain their domestic strife can only be a short-term measure.

For India, this change in the power dynamics poses many challenges. It must move in a planned and cautious manner in spite of the public anger and war cries. Any kind of military action will be playing right into General Kiyani's hands. We have to build international pressure on Pakistan to put terror groups out of business and take steps to strengthen its democratic forces. A failed Pakistan is of no benefit to us. If none of these work, we reserve the right to take appropriate unilateral action. We must not let these Machiavellian generals succeed in their evil designs.

(Aroon Purie)



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